

Digital Literacy

Assignment Report

CSE0001 – Digital Literacy

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1. Introduction

I mean, to be honest, when I first learned that we were going to be taking a course in Digital Literacy, I was a little skeptical. I mean, I use my phone and my laptop every day, so how different could this be from what I already know? But as the semester has progressed, I think I'm starting to realize that there is a pretty big difference between simply using the internet and understanding how digital tools work, their significance, and how to use them in a way that is both productive and responsible.

Basically, digital literacy is the ability to locate good sources of online information, make sense of the information we find online, write good online content, communicate online in an effective manner, and do it in an appropriate and professional way. And of course, we also need to know how to do it in a safe manner. And let's be real, in today's world where pretty much everything we do, whether it is for jobs, research, or other things, is done through some sort of digital means. These are not optional skills, but really necessary ones. As an undergraduate student studying Mechanical Engineering, I work a lot with data, working with research papers, and working with other students on projects. A lot of these things are done online. So, this course really felt applicable to what I do, although I didn't realize it would at first. These exercises in this assignment really encouraged me to think beyond simply using these tools, but really think about them: how do they work, what are the risks of them, and how can we best utilize them.

This report will cover everything I did throughout these five tasks, including creating an infographic, creating professional profiles, coding online platforms, writing proper emails, and understanding cybercrime. Everything in this report is based on what I did and what I learned from it.

2. Objectives of the Assignment

The assignment had a fairly broad set of goals, which I think made it more interesting than a typical exam-style task. Rather than just testing theoretical knowledge, it pushed us to actually do things. Here is what we were working toward:

- Finding out what the concept of digital literacy actually is and how it is important in the modern world.
- Finding out about the types of digital tools that are out there which can actually be helpful in increasing one's productivity.
- Developing a proper online presence, especially on GitHub and LinkedIn, which can be seen by potential employers.
- Practicing beginner-level code using online resources to get more comfortable with coding.
- Finding out how to write a proper professional email that gets the point across without being awkward or sloppy.
- Find out more about the threats that are out there online, ranging from phishing scams to identity theft.

Looking at this list as a whole, what I find interesting is how these goals connect to each other. Safe internet habits are not really separate from professional communication or platform use — they all feed into being someone who is capable and trustworthy in digital spaces.

3. Task 1 – Digital Literacy Infographic

Overview

For this task, I had to create a visual infographic that explained key concepts of digital literacy in a way that was easy for students to understand at a glance. I used Canva for this, mainly because it has a good selection of templates and I had used it a little bit before. The goal was to pick at least three topics and present them clearly without making the infographic feel cluttered or overwhelming.

Topics I Covered

After thinking about it for a while, I decided to focus on the following areas because they felt the most immediately useful for someone my age:

- What digital literacy actually is and why it has become such a widely discussed skill
- Safe internet habits — things like password strength, phishing awareness, and VPN use
- How to write a professional email, because this comes up more than people expect
- Maintaining a responsible presence on social media

What I Learned from Doing This

I found that designing the infographic was more difficult than I expected, not from a technical standpoint, but from a standpoint of what information to include and what information to omit. When you are working within a certain amount of space, you are forced to think of what information is most important for someone to know.

One thing that surprised me while conducting this research was the number of people that are still using easily guessable passwords, such as their birthdate or their own name. I knew this was a problem, but seeing statistics on this issue really made me realize how big of a problem it was. It also led me to think about how I might be contributing to this problem, so I ended up changing a few of my own passwords.

I ended up designing an infographic that looked professional but not boring. It had a dark blue and purple color scheme and icons for each section. I ended up sharing this in the class group, and I got a few responses from people saying that it was easy to read.

4. Task 2 – Professional Platform Setup

Overview

This task was about getting properly set up on the platforms that professionals and academics actually use. It sounds straightforward, but there is a meaningful difference between having an account somewhere and having a profile that actually represents you well. That distinction was the whole point of this task.

GitHub Profile

I had heard of GitHub before this course, but I had mostly used it just to download code that other people had written. For this task, I created a proper profile README — which is a special repository that GitHub displays at the top of your profile page. Mine included my name, my branch and year, my institution, and a short note about what I am hoping to learn and build.

Getting this set up was genuinely useful because it forced me to think about how I want to present myself to people in the tech world. A GitHub profile is basically a live portfolio. It is the kind of thing that a potential employer or project collaborator might look at before reaching out. Knowing that, I took more care with how I worded things than I might have otherwise.

LinkedIn Profile

I updated my LinkedIn profile with my current degree program, my institution, and my expected graduation year. I also wrote a short summary section. This was harder than it sounds because summarizing who you are and what you want in a few sentences is surprisingly difficult when you are still figuring it out yourself.

Still, the exercise was valuable. LinkedIn is where a lot of internship opportunities and professional connections happen, especially in India's engineering and tech sectors. Having an incomplete or outdated profile is almost worse than not having one, so taking the time to fill it in properly felt worth it.

Other Platforms

I also set up accounts on Kaggle and Stack Overflow. Kaggle was interesting because it showed me just how much free data science practice is available online. Stack Overflow I had visited before whenever I was stuck on something, but creating an account and engaging with it as a platform rather than just a search result felt different.

5. Task 3 – Digital Platforms Practice

Part A – Coding Practice

For the coding part of this task, I chose HackerRank because it seemed the most beginner-friendly. I worked through a basic programming challenge — a simple problem involving input and output formatting in Python. I had done a tiny bit of Python before, but only very informally, so this was genuinely good practice.

Here is roughly how the process went for me:

1. Signed up on HackerRank and explored the available challenge categories.
2. Selected a beginner-level problem in the Python domain called ‘Say Hello, World! With Python’ to get started, then moved on to a slightly harder one.
3. Worked through the logic, made a few mistakes, fixed them, and finally got both challenges to pass.
4. Took a screenshot of my completed challenge page showing the score and the badge I received.
5. Added the screenshot to my GitHub repository under the folder ‘task-3-platforms’.

What I found genuinely useful about this experience was the immediate feedback. You write your code, submit it, and find out right away if it works or not. There is no ambiguity. That kind of rapid loop is really helpful for learning, and it made me want to do a few more challenges even after I had completed the minimum required for the task.

Part B – Google Workspace Collaboration

For the second part of this task, I created a Google Form containing a short digital literacy quiz. The form had exactly five questions — a mix of multiple choice and short answer — designed to test whether students understand some basic concepts about online safety and digital tools.

I set up the form so that responses automatically flowed into a Google Sheet. I actually shared the form with a few friends and collected some real responses, which made it feel less like an exercise and more functional. A few of the responses showed gaps in knowledge that I recognized in myself before doing this assignment — which was a good reminder that this material is not obvious just because the internet feels familiar.

6. Task 4 – Email Etiquette and Social Media Responsibility

Part A – Writing Professional Emails

Email might seem old-fashioned, but it is still the primary way that students communicate with professors, administrators, and professional contacts. And yet, I have seen (and sent) some pretty poorly written emails in my time. This task pushed me to be much more deliberate about it.

I wrote two formal emails as part of this exercise.

Email 1 – Assignment Extension Request.

The first email was about requesting a professor for an extension of the deadline of the assignments. This is something that happens every now and then, and most people either do nothing about it or send something too informal and ambiguous to be taken seriously. Writing this proper email required me to think about what I'm actually asking for, my reason behind the request, and how to do so in the most respectful way possible without going into too much detail or being too dramatic about the whole thing.

The final email looked like this: proper greeting, proper reason, proper request with proper date, and proper closing. It looked like something written by someone who is organized and considers the professor's time, which is exactly the impression one should want to give.

Email 2 – Internship Inquiry

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The second email was addressed to a hypothetical internship coordinator at a company, expressing interest in a summer internship. This one was harder because it required me to sell myself a little, which does not come naturally. I focused on being specific about what kind of work I was interested in, briefly mentioning my background, and keeping the tone enthusiastic but professional.

Both emails followed the same structure: a clear subject line, a proper greeting, a focused body, and a polite closing with my name. Practicing this structure helped me internalize it in a way that just reading about it would not have.

Part B – Social Media Do's and Don'ts

The second part of this task involved putting together a checklist of responsible social media behavior. I approached this by thinking about two sides: things that help you build a positive presence, and things that can quietly damage your reputation or make you a target.

On the positive side, sharing your achievements, verifying news before you share it, keeping your privacy settings strong, and communicating respectfully are all habits that make a real difference over time. On the other side, sharing personal information carelessly, engaging in arguments or spreading rumors, and posting impulsively are the kinds of things that are very easy to do and sometimes very hard to undo.

Something that stayed with me from this section: once something is posted online, you largely lose control over it. That is a reality worth sitting with before you hit 'post' on anything.

7. Task 5 – Cybercrime Awareness

Part A – Cybercrime Case Study

For this task, I wrote a case study focused on UPI fraud, which felt especially relevant given how widely UPI is used in India and how frequently fraud cases are reported. The case study walked through a fairly common scenario: a victim receives a message or call from someone pretending to be a bank representative or a buyer on a resale platform, is asked to 'verify' their account by sharing an OTP or clicking a link, and ends up losing money before they realize what happened.

What I tried to capture in the case study was not just what happened but why it worked — because understanding the psychology behind these scams is what actually helps you resist them. Attackers use urgency, fear, and the appearance of legitimacy to override a person's natural caution. Once you know that pattern, you start noticing it.

The case study covered: what UPI fraud is, how it typically unfolds step by step, who tends to be targeted (often first-time digital payment users, elderly users, or people in stressful situations), and the consequences for victims, which go beyond just financial loss.

Part B – Stay Safe Online Checklist

Based on my research, I also put together a practical checklist of safety habits. These are not advanced technical measures — they are things anyone can do:

- Use unique and strong passwords and avoid reusing passwords for different accounts.
- Enable two-factor authentication if it is available.
- Avoid sharing your OTP, bank PIN, and card information with anyone, irrespective of their claims.
- Try hovering over links before clicking on them to see the actual URL.
- Ensure that websites are using HTTPS before giving any personal information.
- Use only trusted and safe networks and try to use a VPN if you are using public Wi-Fi.
- Ensure that your apps, phone, and computer are updated, as updates often contain security patches.
- Be cautious if you receive emails that try to create a sense of urgency.

Reporting Cybercrime

One thing that came out of my research was that I now know the official channels that one can make reports of cybercrime in India. The official channels are the National Cyber Crime Portal at cybercrime.gov.in and the Cyber Crime Helpline at 1930. There are many people who do not even know that these channels exist or who are too embarrassed to make reports. Therefore, it is easy for fraud to take place. I think that more people should be aware of this. **8.**

Learning Outcomes

Completing this assignment changed how I think about my relationship with digital tools. That sounds like an overstatement, but I mean it in a specific way: I used to think of platforms and apps as just things that exist and work (or do not work). Now I think about them more carefully.

Here is what I actually came away with:

- A much clearer understanding of what digital literacy means in practice, not just as a definition but as a set of habits and decisions.
- Improved confidence with tools like GitHub and LinkedIn, and a better sense of how to present myself professionally online.
- Some foundational coding experience through HackerRank that made programming feel less intimidating.
- A real framework for writing professional emails — something I know I will use many times going forward.
- Genuine awareness of cybercrime tactics and what to do (and what not to do) to protect myself.
- A more thoughtful approach to social media, with a clearer idea of where the lines are between personal expression and professional reputation.

Honestly, the skill I am most glad I developed is probably professional email writing. It is one of those things that seems small until you realize how often it comes up and how much it matters when it does.

9. Conclusion

When I look at this assignment as a whole, what I see is a series of experiences that helped fill in gaps that I didn't know I had. The fact that I'm a student in a technical program does not automatically make me digitally literate in the fuller sense of that word. There's a lot more to it than that.

This course has forced me to think about the digital world not as something I simply use, but as something I'm creating as part of who I am a professional. That's important. That's something that will matter, and will matter increasingly, not less, as I go forward in my academic and professional life.

If I had to distill one thing from this entire assignment and pass it along, it would be that the internet is a place that rewards people who think about it thoughtfully. That is, it rewards people who are curious and cautious, and intentional in their approach to it. That's not only true in terms of safety; it's true in terms of making the most of what these tools really have to offer.